

The Thief's Story

Class 10 CBSE • Footprints Without Feet • Ruskin Bond

Detailed Exam-Oriented Solutions

Complete NCERT exercise solutions, character sketches, vocabulary, important quotations, extracts, very-short/short/long answers, value-based and competency-based questions, plus MCQs.

1. Chapter Information

Title	The Thief's Story
Author	Ruskin Bond
Genre	Short story / first-person narrative
Main Characters	Hari Singh, Anil

2. Character Sketches

Hari Singh

A fifteen-year-old experienced thief who changes his name frequently to avoid the police. He is clever, observant and skilled at gaining people's confidence. However, Anil's trust and offer of education awaken his conscience. After stealing ₹600, Hari realises that education and respect can give him a better future, so he returns the money and chooses the path of learning.

Anil

A young, kind and trusting struggling writer. He has irregular income but willingly gives Hari food, shelter and opportunities to learn. He trusts Hari even after the theft and quietly gives him another chance. His kindness and faith in reform play a major role in Hari's transformation.

3. Important Words & Meanings

flattery	insincere praise used to please someone
modestly	without boasting
appealing	attractive or pleasing
unlined	showing no signs of worry
grunting	making low rough sounds
cheque	a written order directing a bank to pay money
confidence	trust or belief in someone
education	the process of learning knowledge and skills
conscience	inner sense of right and wrong
deserted	empty or without people
betrayal	act of being disloyal to someone's trust
temptation	strong desire to do something, especially something wrong

4. Important Quotations / Lines

“I was still a thief when I met Anil.”

Significance: Hari openly admits his criminal past, establishing the starting point of his moral transformation.

“A little flattery helps in making friends.”

Significance: Hari understands how to manipulate people and uses praise as a tool to gain trust.

“It’s easy to rob a greedy man... but it’s difficult to rob a careless man.”

Significance: Hari distinguishes between different victims and reveals his experience as a thief.

“I knew that once I could write like an educated man there would be no limit to what I could achieve.”

Significance: Education begins to appear to Hari as a path to a respectable and successful life.

“He had given me a fifty-rupee note.”

Significance: The note signals Anil’s quiet acceptance of Hari’s return and his decision to give the boy another chance.

5. Complete NCERT Textbook Solutions

A. Read and Find Out — Page 8

Q. Who does ‘I’ refer to in this story?

Answer: ‘I’ refers to Hari Singh, the fifteen-year-old thief who narrates the story.

Q. What is he “a fairly successful hand” at?

Answer: He is a fairly successful thief, skilled at stealing and gaining people's confidence without being caught.

Q. What does he get from Anil in return for his work?

Answer: Anil provides him with food and a place to stay. He also teaches him cooking and begins teaching him to read, write sentences and add numbers. Hari also makes a small profit while buying household supplies.

B. Read and Find Out — Page 10

Q. How does the thief think Anil will react to the theft?

Answer: Hari thinks Anil will be sad rather than angry. The sadness would come from the betrayal of trust rather than simply from the loss of money.

Q. What does he say about the different reactions of people when they are robbed?

Answer: He says a greedy man shows fear, a rich man shows anger, and a poor man shows acceptance when robbed.

Q. Does Anil realise that he has been robbed?

Answer: Yes. The next morning Anil gives Hari a fifty-rupee note that is still wet from the rain and says they will begin writing sentences. His behaviour shows that he knows what happened but chooses not to expose Hari.

C. Think About It

Q. What are Hari Singh’s reactions to the prospect of receiving an education? Do they change over time? What makes him return to Anil?

Answer: Initially Hari sees education mainly as another useful skill. Gradually, he realises that being educated can give him opportunities beyond theft. After stealing the money, he imagines the future he would lose by leaving Anil: education, respect and a better life. This change in thinking, together with his conscience, makes him return.

Q. Why does not Anil hand the thief over to the police? Do you think most people would have done so? In what ways is Anil different from such employers?

Answer: Anil understands that Hari is young and capable of changing. Instead of humiliating or punishing him, he silently gives him another opportunity. Many people might report a thief immediately, but Anil is unusually trusting, forgiving and interested in Hari's education and future.

D. Talk About It — Model Answers

Q. Do you think people like Anil and Hari Singh are found only in fiction, or are there such people in real life?

Answer: People with similar qualities can be found in real life. Some young people may make wrong choices because of poverty, lack of guidance or circumstances, while kind and trusting people may help them change. The story is fictional but its human behaviour is realistic.

Q. Do you think it a significant detail in the story that Anil is a struggling writer? Does this explain his behaviour in any way?

Answer: Yes. Anil's irregular income explains why he cannot offer Hari a fixed salary. It also suggests that he understands uncertainty and hardship. His simple lifestyle and kind nature help explain why he is willing to trust and educate Hari.

Q. Can you think and imagine the circumstances that can turn a fifteen-year-old boy into a thief?

Answer: Poverty, lack of family support, hunger, poor education, negative company and repeated exposure to crime can push a child towards theft. Such circumstances do not justify stealing, but they can help explain how a young person may enter a life of crime.

Q. Where is the story set? Which language or languages are spoken in these places? Do you think the characters spoke to each other in English?

Answer: The story is set in India, suggested by names, places and the reference to the Lucknow Express. Hindi and other Indian languages would naturally be spoken in such surroundings. The story is narrated in English for the reader; the characters could have been speaking Hindi or another Indian language in the fictional setting.

6. Extract-Based Questions

"I was still a thief when I met Anil. And though only 15, I was an experienced and fairly successful hand."

1. Who is the speaker?

Answer: Hari Singh.

2. What was he experienced at?

Answer: Stealing and robbing people.

3. How old was he?

Answer: Fifteen.

4. What does this reveal about his past?

Answer: He had already developed considerable experience in theft despite his young age.

"It's easy to rob a greedy man... but it's difficult to rob a careless man."

1. Why is a greedy man easy to rob, according to Hari?

Answer: A greedy man has enough money to lose and may react fearfully.

2. Why is a careless man difficult to rob?

Answer: A careless man may not even notice the theft, which removes the excitement for the thief.

3. What does this show about Hari?

Answer: He is observant and experienced as a thief.

4. Who is the careless man in the story?

Answer: Anil is described as careless about his money and possessions.

"I knew that once I could write like an educated man there would be no limit to what I could achieve."

1. What changes in Hari's thinking?

Answer: He begins to see a future beyond stealing.

2. What does education represent to him?

Answer: It represents opportunity, respect and independence.

3. Why does this thought matter to the plot?

Answer: It becomes the main reason he reconsiders the theft.

4. What finally makes him choose education over theft?

Answer: His conscience and fear of losing Anil's trust, along with the value he places on education.

7. Very Short Answer Questions

Q. Who is the narrator?

Answer: Hari Singh.

Q. How old is Hari Singh?

Answer: Fifteen years old.

Q. Who is Anil?

Answer: A young struggling writer.

Q. How much money does Hari steal?

Answer: Six hundred rupees.

Q. Where does Hari plan to go after the theft?

Answer: Lucknow.

Q. What does Anil promise to teach Hari?

Answer: To write whole sentences and add numbers.

Q. Why does Hari return?

Answer: His conscience and the value of education and trust make him return.

Q. Does Anil openly accuse Hari?

Answer: No.

Q. What is wet the next morning?

Answer: The fifty-rupee note Anil gives Hari is wet from the rain.

Q. What does the ending suggest?

Answer: Hari is ready to begin a new, honest life through education.

8. Short Answer Questions

Q. Why did Hari approach Anil?

Answer: Hari wanted to gain Anil's confidence so that he could eventually rob him. He noticed that Anil looked kind, easy-going and simple, which seemed to make him an easy target.

Q. Why did Anil employ Hari even though he could not pay him?

Answer: Anil was kind and willing to give Hari food and shelter. He also saw an opportunity to teach the boy useful skills rather than simply turning him away.

Q. Why was stealing Anil's money emotionally difficult for Hari?

Answer: Anil trusted Hari completely and had offered him education and a better future. Hari realised that stealing would not only take money but also destroy that trust.

Q. Why did Hari not board the train?

Answer: At the railway station Hari began thinking about the value of education and Anil's trust. He realised that six hundred rupees could not buy the respect and opportunities that education could provide.

Q. How does Anil's silence affect Hari?

Answer: Anil's silence shows forgiveness and gives Hari a second chance. It also makes Hari aware of the depth of Anil's trust, strengthening his decision to change.

9. Long Answer Questions

Q. Describe Hari Singh's transformation in the story.

Answer: Hari begins as an experienced fifteen-year-old thief who lies about his name and plans to exploit Anil's trust. However, Anil treats him kindly, gives him food and shelter, and offers to educate him. After Hari steals ₹600, he initially plans to escape, but his conscience makes him think about what he will lose. He realises that education can help him become a clever, respected person. He returns the money and comes back to Anil. His transformation is therefore driven by trust, education and the possibility of a better future.

Q. How does Anil's character contribute to Hari's reform?

Answer: Anil is generous, trusting and patient. He does not judge Hari solely by his past. He gives him food, shelter and work, and more importantly offers education. Even after discovering the theft, Anil does not expose Hari. His quiet forgiveness communicates that trust can be restored and that a person can change. Anil's behaviour therefore becomes the moral influence that helps Hari choose honesty.

Q. Why is education presented as more valuable than money in the story?

Answer: Money can provide temporary comfort, but education can create lasting opportunities. Hari can steal a few hundred rupees, but he realises that education may help him earn honestly, gain respect and become independent. This understanding makes him return the stolen money. The story therefore presents education as a means of transforming one's future.

10. Value-Based Questions

Q. What lesson does the story teach about giving a second chance?

Answer: A second chance can help a person correct mistakes when it is combined with responsibility and guidance. Anil's trust gives Hari an opportunity to reform rather than pushing him further into crime.

Q. How can teachers and parents apply the lesson of the story?

Answer: They can correct wrongdoing firmly but also help young people understand consequences and provide constructive opportunities such as education, skill-building and guidance.

Q. Why is trust powerful but also risky?

Answer: Trust can encourage honesty and reform, as it does with Hari, but it can also be misused. Responsible trust should therefore be accompanied by guidance and awareness.

11. Additional Important Questions

Q. Why does Hari change his name every month?

Answer: To remain ahead of the police and former employers and make it difficult for them to trace him.

Q. Why does Hari call Anil careless?

Answer: Anil keeps his money casually and does not worry much about it, making him an easy target.

Q. Why does Hari feel that Anil will not be angry?

Answer: He believes Anil is too kind and would be hurt more by the betrayal than by the financial loss.

Q. What is the importance of the fifty-rupee note?

Answer: It symbolises Anil's quiet acknowledgement of the theft and his willingness to give Hari another opportunity.

Q. How is the ending significant?

Answer: The ending suggests a fresh beginning: Hari returns to learning and Anil's trust instead of continuing as a thief.

12. CBSE Exam-Oriented Questions

Q. Competency-based: Hari has a chance to steal money but also has a chance to learn. Which choice represents long-term thinking? Explain.

Answer: Choosing education represents long-term thinking because it can create continuing opportunities and independence, whereas stolen money provides only temporary benefit and carries the risk of punishment.

Q. Case-based: A student has made a serious mistake but wants to improve. What can be learned from Anil's response?

Answer: Correction can be more effective when a person is held accountable but also given a constructive path to change. Anil's trust and educational support help Hari reform.

Q. Analytical: 'Hari was not reformed by fear of punishment but by the value of trust and education.' Discuss.

Answer: Hari does not return because he suddenly fears the police. He returns after thinking about losing Anil's trust and the opportunity to become educated and respected. The change is therefore internal and value-based.

13. MCQs

1. Hari Singh was approximately:
A. 10 B. 15 C. 18 D. 25
2. Anil was approximately:
A. 15 B. 20 C. 25 D. 35
3. Hari met Anil at:
A. a railway station B. a wrestling match C. a market D. a school
4. Hari stole:
A. ₹200 B. ₹400 C. ₹600 D. ₹1,000
5. Hari planned to catch the:
A. 8.30 Express B. 9.30 Express C. 10.30 Express D. 11.30 Express
6. Anil promised to teach Hari:
A. driving B. writing and adding numbers C. boxing D. cooking only
7. Hari returned because he valued:
A. food B. clothes C. education and trust D. the police
8. Anil was a:
A. businessman B. writer C. teacher D. doctor
9. The story is narrated by:
A. Anil B. Hari Singh C. the police D. a third-person narrator
10. The final mood of the story is mainly:
A. hopeful B. tragic C. frightening D. angry

MCQ Answer Key

1-B, 2-C, 3-B, 4-C, 5-C, 6-B, 7-C, 8-B, 9-B, 10-A

14. Teacher's Note on Answer Writing

2-3 marks: Answer directly and include the key reason/event.

5-6 marks: Use a clear opening, 3-4 developed points and a concluding inference.

Extracts: Identify context/speaker first, then answer precisely.